Corps at that time had no information as they had been cut off from 4 Division since the morning. Jaswant Singh promptly put in a call to the air chief, and after briefing him on the situation, with his usual dash of humour added ‘Well Sir, if the army doesn’t know what to do, I will send our fighters into action and I want your permission for it.’ Obviously there was an explosion at the other end of the line, for after a while Jaswant Singh spoke again, ‘Yes Sir, of course, I know Sir, don’t you worry. It was only meant to be a joke.’

In Tibet, unlike the Arakans where the Japanese infantry had plenty of vegetation to cover their tracks, there is excellent visibility and no natural cover available. In fact, on 21 October, AN 12s and Packets flying in the Chushul area had reported a three-kilometre-long Chinese column proceeding towards the Spanggur Gap. The IAF would have had a definite edge over their Chinese counterparts in offensive sweeps over the area, for aircraft taking off from the plains would have operated with full loads while the Chinese would have had to cope with the drawback of operating out of high altitude airfields in Tibet. As for the retaliatory bombing of Indian cities—forget about Calcutta, the Chinese Air Force would have been hard-pressed to get to Gorakhpur. Also, at that time, the Chinese did not have advanced runways in Tibet, nor had they begun to deploy missiles.

Air Chief Marshal S. K. Mehra, confirmed that the IAF was just raring to have a go. A squadron leader at the time, Mehra himself had visited most of the Indian positions in NEFA to work out probable lines of attack and assess the terrain. In addition, fighter pilots were flying in transport aircraft to familiarize themselves with the terrain whenever possible.

According to Jaggi Nath (the Canberra pilot who photographed the Aksai Chin highway) he met Kaul in Army HQ with photographs of Chinese deployment after a routine sortie over Sinkiang and Tibet. ‘We had the run of the skies, there were simply no Chinese aircraft around that could threaten us. We got pictures of everything—vehicles, guns, their defences, especially in the DBO, Qara Qash and Galwan sectors.’ However, Kaul showed little interest in what the squadron leader had to say. ‘He kept saying how he was just coming from or going to meet the prime minister. For us, not used to the functioning of Army HQ, it looked like a parody.’

The problem probably lay in the difference between availability of intelligence and the ability to interpret it. Mullik’s view, that come what may, the Chinese would never attack obviously permeated down ranks in